

Got criticized for using AI because of environmental impacts

Posted by u/newveganhere • 0 points • 23 comments

Admittedly I use AI a lot for work and just in general. I know it has high emissions but as a childfree vegan who doesn't commute for work and rarely travels by air anymore, I feel like I have already taken significant steps in my personal life to reduce my own emissions.

So when she gave me a lecture, I responded with "well it does have high emissions but I've drastically cut my personal emissions by (reasons listed above)" and then she was like well still, you should try to not use it. You don't have to use it.

So I said, well you don't have to eat animal products or have children, so why do you think it's ok to do those and not to use AI? Either of those things is WAY more emissions that even if I used AI for 8 hours a day for the rest of my life. And she just stares at me speechless as if I insulted her.

Like why is it ok to try and lecture me for my lifestyle choice but not lecture you for your lifestyle choice? If you can't take it don't dish it out!

Comments

u/Falkoro • 1 points • 2025-03-24 22:32 UTC

I really don't care anymore about the climate. Either we fix it by geo engineering or we don't. But in the meantime I am chilling in my hottub.

I eat plant based for the animals - I don't want to kill dogs or cars so why should I support inflicting extreme harm on other sentient beings?

The thing is with climate - personal impact does not matter one bit. We have over 8 billion people on this planet, lol.

u/VeganAirbenderAvatar • -1 points • 2025-03-24 22:14 UTC

Carnists are just hypocrites. A single carnist burger consumes more emissions what a vegan using ChatGPT their whole lives. If the whole world went vegan, nobody would be worried about the AI consumption.

u/Dazzling_Wash_2370 • 0 points • 2025-03-26 04:13 UTC

Wrong

u/newveganhere • 1 points • 2025-03-24 23:41 UTC

Exactly. People do not realize by the numbers how terrible animal product consumption is for the planet, especially at these sky-high volumes of consumption we see today. Even 15% of the world going vegan would be a considerable impact; or even the world reducing their consumption by 15% would have a considerable impact. Obviously reductionism is not veganism but purely in an emissions lens, reductionism or fully plant

based eating should be at the very top of anyone's list if they are concerned about their personal emissions. AI use is not even in the top 50.

u/lcy_Minimum_8687 • 1 points • 2025-03-24 21:27 UTC

not only is using ai bad for the environment, you're also supporting theft from artists and writers since what they create is being used for generating images, articles etc. without their consent, so many of them have lost jobs and are having a hard time getting another since so many companies are now using ai instead of employing real people. And by using ai you're also training it, thereby helping companies take more jobs from people.

Why even bother cutting down on those other things if you're just going to be selfish and lazy and use ai. It's very easy to just simply not use ai compared to what you've stopped using already.

u/veganvampirebat • 2 points • 2025-03-24 20:46 UTC

You're both right but that's also one of the many reasons why environmentalism isn't *as* strong of an argument for veganism as some think. You could make trades to be more environmentally friendly than the average vegan. It's just a big bonus.

u/jenever_r • -1 points • 2025-03-24 20:46 UTC

There's a lot of bullshit around when it comes to AI energy usage.

<https://www.nature.com/articles/s41598-024-54271-x>

Some models are energy-intensive to train, but so is every other system performing complex calculations. Using the resulting AI systems isn't a huge problem and is often far less impactful than doing the work manually.

The BERT model training was the equivalent of one transatlantic flight for one person.

Then you have to factor in how AI is being used. It's so much more efficient than humans in processing data that it's already advancing things like materials science. That includes new battery technology and advances in medical tech. It's saved years of research and experimentation.

https://www.technologyreview.com/2023/11/29/1084061/deepmind-ai-tool-for-new-materials-discovery/?truid=&utm_source=the_algorithm&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=the_algorithm.unpaid.engagement&utm_content=12-04-2023

"It uses a lot of energy" is a dramatic oversimplification. Using a credit card or doing a Google search also use a lot of energy, but stuff like crypto currencies and AI seem to be singled out for disproportionate criticism. It's all a bit Luddite.

u/newveganhere • 1 points • 2025-03-24 23:38 UTC

This. Thank you. I'm a climate change policy researcher and I guess what I should have articulated better is that comparing the overly simplistic "AI has huge emissions" is not even in the same playing field in terms of emissions as a plant based diet or even an omni diet with considerably reduced animal Product consumption; and diet, while veg significant is a completely lower level in comparison to having children, or even just having one less child.

u/Confused_Sparrow • 1 points • 2025-03-24 20:43 UTC

It's always nice to be able to put the impacts of the use of AI into perspective. My favourite resource in that regard is this article I learnt about from u/DependentlyHyped about 2 weeks ago in [another AI related post here] (https://www.reddit.com/r/vegan/comments/1j7jic7/do_you_think_ai_chatbots_actually_help_your/): <https://andymasley.substack.com/p/individual-ai-use-is-not-bad-for>

My key takeaways from it and the math of my personal usage are basically that depending on how I use it, the usage of the already trained models can be less resource-costly than a sequence of Google searches or trying to find a specific piece of information in a YouTube video.

u/Confused_Sparrow • 5 points • 2025-03-24 20:42 UTC

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u/extropiantranshuman • -2 points • 2025-03-24 20:39 UTC

someone told me I'm an ai today just to dismiss what I say. It's insane - because they don't care to address the conversation - it's the new modern excuse for handwaving! It's pretty sad.

It's funny - I bet they used an electronic device with an internet to tell you that.

With all of these - we have to think about the alternatives. If I say didn't use youtube to go on vacation - I'd go in person - and that's way more emissions. Or if I'm looking on the internet for something - the scouring for ages what ai can share with me in a few minutes - it's a massive difference! So the alternative will have high emissions too - so what is their problem really?

Well some people just want to criticize everything because they can't manage their own life so they have to go and both others, which I agree - is a severe waste of everyone's time. If this person really had a problem with you using ai - where is she helping you out in your life so you don't have to?

Exactly - if she doesn't want to lift a finger to help, then it's environmentally wasteful to complain on top of the ai usage.

Look - if it's really truly an issue - maybe we can collectively create an ai bank of vegan answers on a website that the ai has given us, so it's only used once by 1 person and that's it? Will that solve your and their issues and make everyone happy?

u/RaspberryTurtle987 • 10 points • 2025-03-24 20:39 UTC

AI is bad for many reasons other than just environmental ones.

u/basedfrosti • 1 points • 2025-03-24 20:28 UTC

You are both hypocrites.

u/Far_Excuse_1176 • 4 points • 2025-03-24 20:24 UTC

I think there might always be some hypocrisy while discussing ethics, since all of us could be doing more. Maybe this is more true for her, but it seems to always go both ways. That doesn't mean either of you are wrong in what you care about.

u/floopsyDoodle • 2 points • 2025-03-24 20:21 UTC

>Admittedly I use AI a lot for work and just in general. I know it has high emissions but as a childfree vegan who doesn't commute for work and rarely travels by air anymore, I feel like I have already taken significant steps in my personal life to reduce my own emissions.

If you are using it a lot, you may want to look into getting a decent video card (if you don't have one) and setting up a DeepSeek LLM locally. It will use far less power and resources, won't steal your data or sell everything you say to advertisers, and it's never "down". I set one up recently and it was pretty easy, I just need a better video card to get the 600B point dataset, currently I can only run the 70b.

>And she just stares at me speechless as if I insulted her.

haha Yeah, Carnists will do that... You're both right, but you're also right that their impact is FAR larger and it's pretty silly to be trying to insult you for using LLMs without even thinking about their own lifestyle impact.

> If you can't take it don't dish it out!

Sadly most humans don't accept that. It's usually "I can insult and degrade you all I want for any little thing, but if you do it to me, even if it's correct, I'll freak the heck out and start screaming bloody murder". The joys of being a vocal moral activist... :)

u/freethenipple420 • 9 points • 2025-03-24 20:20 UTC

The more I read the cringier it gets...

u/sleepyriver troll • 15 points • 2025-03-24 20:18 UTC

You guys can both be right. If your goal is to minimize your carbon footprint but you drove a F-250, it would still be appropriate to call you out on it.

That being said, she should also be able to take it if she is willing to dish it. We can all improve and it shouldn't be done in accusatory ways.

u/bobi2393 • 1 points • 2025-03-24 20:55 UTC

It helps to understand emissions from different activities, like flying in a jet is a lot worse than running your computer for the same amount of time. I would guess the person OP is talking about severely overestimates power consumption of using an already-existing large language model for periodic queries, which uses a trivial amount of power. Maybe she read something about various combined global usage of AI by billions of people, but on an individual level, unless you're generating AI images 24/7 or doing something else on a continual basis, you'd save more energy by not using a refrigerator, stove, furnace, air conditioner, or car.

u/newveganhere • 1 points • 2025-03-24 23:31 UTC

This. And I guess I should add I am a climate change policy researcher so I am quite familiar with the actual amounts of emissions associated with various lifestyle choices; AI use is just not even in the top fifty. Also, as you stated the image generation is the heavy issue and I've actually never used it for that; it's more to speed up collating research for work, English to French conversion and random queries that I could just ask Google but AI does a more complete job in responding

u/FloralSkyles • 3 points • 2025-03-24 20:16 UTC

While I do understand your frustration and you aren't wrong that the person is a hypocrite, using AI is still awful

u/EvnClaire • -1 points • 2025-03-24 20:40 UTC

casually using AI for images is no different than streaming netflix in terms of environmental impact.

u/FloralSkyles • 5 points • 2025-03-24 20:41 UTC

not at all true because you are helping train the algorithm. Not only that but you are helping provide their shareholders metrics that AI is \"useful\" and use should be expanded. Moreover, if you are doing it all day like OP said, it's way worse than just watching netflix.

It's also inherently artistic theft.

u/EvnClaire • 0 points • 2025-03-31 02:22 UTC

1. i've never heard that using AI helps train the algorithm. i'll assume it does-- this is still no different than streaming netflix.
2. sure, you probably are indicating to the shareholders. much like streaming netflix.
3. obviously if you're doing it all day it's worse for the environment. that's irrelevant to the point i made in my comment.
4. AI is not artistic theft in the same way that text generative AI or AI-based algorithms aren't artistic theft.

u/D_D • 27 points • 2025-03-24 20:15 UTC

This is what happens when you start conflating veganism with health and environmentalism. Veganism is about ending the exploiting of non-human animals.

u/newveganhere • 1 points • 2025-03-24 23:27 UTC

I agree but we werent discussing animals; only emissions and reducing one's footprint. plant based eating is definitely one of the most impactful personal choices one can make to reduce their emissions; not having children or having one less child is colossal. AI use pales in comparison to either.